Portfolio Reflection: Your Growth as a Writer

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FIGURE 20.1 Mount Hood, Oregon. Seeing and reseeing, as in this lake reflection, is a practice that may help you think and understand with greater clarity. (credit: "Mount Hood reflected in Mirror Lake, Oregon" by Oregon's Mt. Hood Territory/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

CHAPTER OUTLINE

20.1 Thinking Critically about Your Semester
20.2 Reflection Trailblazer: Sandra Cisneros
20.3 Glance at Genre: Purpose and Structure
20.4 Annotated Sample Reading: "Don't Expect Congrats" by Dale Trumbore
20.5 Writing Process: Looking Back, Looking Forward
20.6 Editing Focus: Pronouns
20.7 Evaluation: Evaluating Self-Reflection
20.8 Spotlight on … Pronouns in Context

INTRODUCTION Reflecting on your work is an important step in your growth as a writer. Reflection allows you to recognize the ways in which you have mastered some skills and have addressed instances when your intention and execution fail to match. By recognizing previous challenges and applying learned strategies for addressing them, you demonstrate improvement and progress as a writer. This kind of reflection is an example of recursive (https://openstax.org/r/recursivity). At this point in the semester, you know that writing is a recursive process: you prewrite, you write, you revise, you edit, you reflect, you revise, and so on. In working through a writing assignment, you learn and understand more about particular sections of your draft, and you can go back and revise them. The ability to return to your writing and exercise objectivity and honesty about it is one of skills you have practiced during this journey. You are now able to evaluate your own work, accept another's critique of your writing, and make meaningful revisions.

In this chapter, you will review your work from earlier chapters and write a reflection that captures your growth, feelings, and challenges as a writer. In your reflection, you will apply many of the writing, reasoning, and evidentiary strategies you have already used in other papers—for example, analysis, evaluation, comparison and contrast, problem and solution, cause and effect, examples, and anecdotes.

When looking at your earlier work, you may find that you cringe at those papers and wonder what you were thinking when you wrote them. If given that same assignment, you now would know how to produce a more polished paper. This response is common and is evidence that you have learned quite a bit about writing.

20.1 Thinking Critically about Your Semester

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Reflect on and write about the development of composing processes and how those processes affect your work.
- Demonstrate honesty and objectivity in reflecting on written work.

You have written your way through a long semester, and the journey is nearly complete. Now is the time to step back and reflect on what you have written, what you have mastered, what skill gaps remain, and what you will do to continue growing and improving as a communicator. This reflection will be based on the work you have done and what you have learned during the semester. Because the subject of this reflection is you and your work, no further research is required. The information you need is in the work you have done in this course and in your head. Now, you will work to organize and transfer this information to an organized written text. Every assignment you have completed provides you with insight into your writing process as you think about the assignment's purpose, its execution, and your learning along the way. The skill of reflection requires you to be critical and honest about your habits, feelings, skills, and writing. In the end, you will discover that you have made progress as a writer, perhaps in ways not yet obvious.



20.2 Trailblazer

Reflection Trailblazer: Sandra Cisneros

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Identify and analyze an author's reflections.
- Demonstrate the ability to think critically about a writer's reflections.



FIGURE 20.2 Sandra Cisneros (credit: "Sandra leyendo parte de su obra" by Embassy of the United States-Argentina/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

"She experiments, creating a text that is as succinct and flexible as poetry, snapping sentences into fragments."

Finding a Home in Writing

Poet and novelist Sandra Cisneros (b. 1954) is best known for her novel *The House on Mango Street* (1983). Born in Chicago, Illinois, Cisneros was the only girl in a family of seven children. When she was a child, her father moved the family several times between Chicago and Mexico City, the capital of Mexico. With these moves back and forth between the two countries, Cisneros felt detached from both cultures, forcing her to create her own path to understand herself better.

In school, Cisneros was encouraged to write poems and quickly became known for her writing. However, her interest in writing did not fully take hold until college, when she took a creative writing course. She graduated with a BA from Loyola University in Chicago in 1976 and earned an MFA from the Writers' Workshop at the University of Iowa in 1978. While there, she had an epiphany: "I was in this class, we were talking about memory and the imagination,... and I realized: 'My god, I'm... different from everybody in this classroom'" (Rodríguez Aranda 65). This important reflection encouraged Cisneros to write about what others could not: her own experience. The unique part poetry, part prose writing style that she crafted to relay her experiences eventually found its place among traditional literary genres, giving voice to the once voiceless.

In her memoir, *A House of My Own: Stories from My Life* (https://openstax.org/r/A_House) (2015), Cisneros reflects on her journey as a writer through subjects such as autonomy, home, culture, and environment. She does so by introducing her memories, which develop into a kind of dialogue between the young writer she once was and the successful writer she is today. In the title essay, "A House of My Own"—originally the introduction to the 25th anniversary edition of *The House on Mango Street*—Cisneros writes, "The young woman in this photograph is me.... She thinks stories are about beauty." By describing herself in the third person from the vantage point of herself as a successful writer, Cisneros creates space for reflection—the act of thinking about the arc of her life. She wonders how this young woman with so many fears had the courage to chart her own path in life. Upon reflection, previously unexamined gifts from her parents provide some answers. In *A House of My Own,* Cisneros says that she became a writer because of her mother, "who was unhappy being a mother" and was "banging on the bars of her cell all her life," and because of her father, who wanted Cisneros to marry and have babies and so didn't mind if she "majored in something silly like English": "In a sense, everything I have ever written has been for him, to win his approval." Cisneros's reflection suggests that in some ways, her life has been about rebirthing herself into a form that her mother would be proud of and a form her father would come to understand—a form beyond the circumstances of her original birth.

This reflective dialogue across time mirrors the way in which Cisneros sees herself: as someone who writes from multiple perspectives. Being an American and a Mexican, she writes in two languages and uses elements

of both cultures to create characters that she picks up from memory, chance meetings, visits to various places, and dreams. She cobbles these parts together to form a title or maybe just a first line, giving her mind time to percolate, waiting for the rest of the story to emerge. This is the work of reflection—giving oneself time to think, to make connections, to feel, and to put words to ideas.

Discussion Questions

1. In what ways did the realization that she was different from other students spur Sandra Cisneros's journey as a writer?
2. What is the purpose of reflection in Cisneros's writing?
3. What strategies does Cisneros use to generate reflective writing?
4. What themes emerge when you think about your journey as a writer this semester? Do similarities exist between your themes and Cisneros's? Explain
5. What dialogue might emerge between the writer you were at the beginning of the semester and the writer you are now? If applicable, describe an epiphany, or sudden realization, you might have had about your writing.

20.3 Glance at Genre: Purpose and Structure

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Identify conventions of reflection regarding structure, paragraphing, and tone.
- Articulate how genre conventions are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.
- Adapt composing processes for a variety of technologies and modalities.

Reflective writing is the practice of thinking about an event, an experience, a memory, or something imagined and expressing its larger meaning in written form. Reflective writing comes from the author's specific perspective and often contemplates the way an event (or something else) has affected or even changed the author's life.

Areas of Exploration

When you write a reflective piece, consider three main areas of exploration as shown in Figure 20.3. The first is the **happening**. This area consists of the events included in the reflection. For example, you will be examining writing assignments from this course. As you describe the assignments, you also establish context for the reflection so that readers can understand the circumstances involved. For each assignment, ask yourself these questions: *What was the assignment? How did I approach the assignment? What did I do to start this assignment? What did I think about the assignment?* If you think of other questions, use them. Record your answers because they will prove useful in the second area.

The second area is **reflection**. When you reflect on the happening, you go beyond simply writing about the specific details of the assignment; you move into the writing process and an explanation of what you learned from doing the work. In addition, you might recognize—and note—a change in your skills or way of thinking. Ask yourself these questions: *What works effectively in this text? What did I learn from this assignment? How is this assignment useful? How did I feel when I was working on this assignment?* Again, you can create other questions, and note your responses because you will use them to write a reflection.

The third area is **action**. Here, you decide what to do next and plan the steps needed to reach that goal. Ask yourself: *What does (and does not) work effectively in this text? How can I continue to improve in this area? What should I do now? What has changed in my thinking? How would I change my approach to this assignment if I had to do another one like it?* Base your responses to these questions on what you have learned,

and implement these elements in your writing.

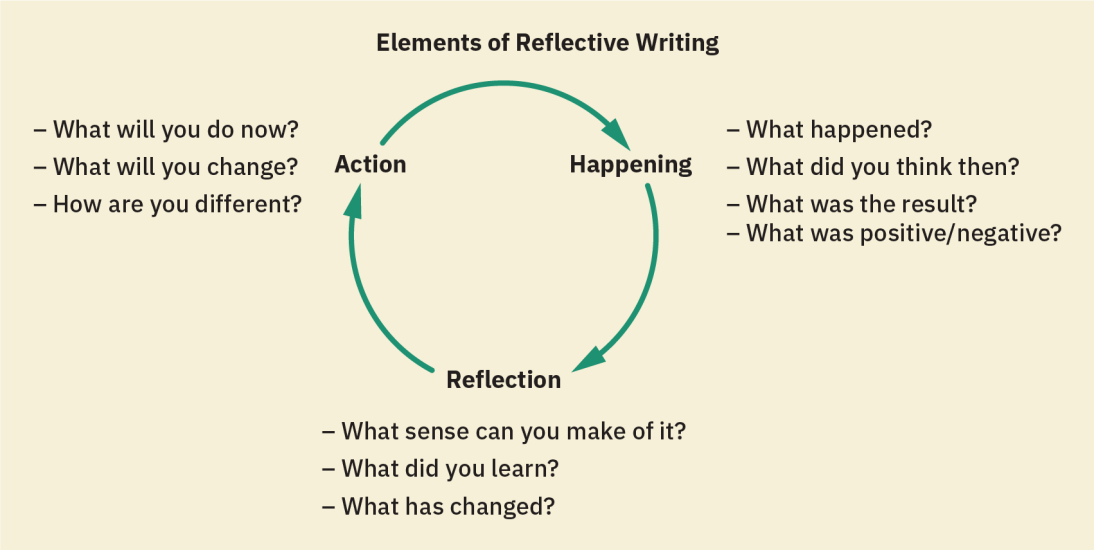


FIGURE 20.3 Elements of reflective writing (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

Format of Reflective Writing

Unlike thesis statements, which often come at the beginning of an essay, the main point of a piece of reflective writing may be conveyed only indirectly and nearly always emerges at the end, almost like an epiphany, or sudden realization. With this structure, readers are drawn into the act of reflecting and become more curious about what the writer is thinking and feeling. ln other words, reflective writers are musing, exploring, or wondering rather than arguing. In fact, reflective essays are most enlightening when they are not obviously instructive or assertive. However, even though reflective writing does not present an explicit argument, it still includes evidence and cohesion and provides lessons to be learned. As such, elements of persuasion or argument often appear in reflective essays.

Discovery through Writing

Keep in mind, too, that when you start to reflect on your growth as a writer, you may not realize what caused you to explore a particular memory. In other words, writers may choose to explore an idea, such as why something got their attention, and only by recalling the details of that event do they discover the reason it first drew their attention.

When you tell the story of your writing journey this semester, you may find that more was on your mind than you realized. The writing itself is one thing, but the meaning of what you learned becomes something else, and you may deliberately share how that second level, or deeper meaning or feeling, emerged through the act of storytelling. For example, in narrating a writing experience, you may step back, pause, and let readers know, "Wait a minute, something else is going on here." An explanation of the new understanding, for both you and your readers, can follow this statement. Such pauses are a sign that connections are being made—between the present and the past, the concrete and the abstract, the literal and the symbolic. They signal to readers that the essay or story is about to move in a new and less predictable direction. Yet each idea remains connected through the structure of happenings, reflections, and actions.

Sometimes, slight shifts in voice or tone accompany reflective pauses as a writer moves closer to what is really on their mind. The exact nature of these shifts will, of course, be determined by the writer's viewpoint. Perhaps one idea that you, as the writer, come up with is the realization that writing a position argument was useful in your history class. You were able to focus more on the material than on *how* to write the paper because you already knew how to craft a position argument. As you work through this process, continue to note these

important little discoveries.

Your Writing Portfolio

As you recall, each chapter in this book has included one or more assignments for a writing portfolio. In simplest terms, a writing portfolio is a collection of your writing contained within a single binder or folder. A portfolio may contain printed copy, or it may be completely digital. Its contents may have been created over a number of weeks, months, or even years, and it may be organized chronologically, thematically, or qualitatively. A portfolio assigned for a class will contain written work to be shared with an audience to demonstrate your writing, learning, and skill progression. This kind of writing portfolio, accumulated during a college course, presents a record of your work over a semester and may be used to assign a grade. Many instructors now offer the option of, or even require, digital **multimodal** portfolios, which include visuals, audio, and/or video in addition to written texts. Your instructor will provide guidelines on how to create a multimodal portfolio, if applicable. You can also learn more about creating a multimodal portfolio (https://openstax.org/r/creating) and view one by a first-year student (https://openstax.org/r/first-year).

Key Terms

As you begin crafting your reflection, consider these elements of reflective writing.

- **Analysis:** When you analyze your own writing, you explain your reasoning or writing choices, thus showing that you understand your progress as a writer.
- **Context:** The context is the circumstances or situation in which the happening occurred. A description of the assignment, an explanation of why it was given, and any other relevant conditions surrounding it would be its context.
- **Description:** Providing specific details, using figurative language and imagery, and even quoting from your papers helps readers visualize and thus share your reflection. When describing, writers may include visuals if applicable.
- **Evaluation:** An effective evaluation points out where you faltered and where you did well. With that understanding, you have a basis to return to your thoughts and speculate about progress you will continue to make in the future.
- **Observation:** Observation is a close look at the writing choices you made and the way you managed the rhetorical situations you encountered. When observing, be objective, and pay attention to the more and less effective parts of your writing.
- **Purpose:** By considering the goals of these previous assignments, you will be better equipped to look at them critically and objectively to understand their larger use in academia.
- **Speculation:** Speculation encourages you to think about your next steps: where you need to improve and where you need to stay sharp to avoid recurring mistakes.
- **Thoughts:** Your thoughts (and feelings) before, during, and after an assignment can provide you with descriptive material. In a reflective essay, writers may choose to indicate their thoughts in a different tense from the one in which they write the essay itself.

When you put these elements together, you will be able to reflect objectively on your own writing. This reflection might include identifying areas of significant improvement and areas that still need more work. In either case, focus on describing, analyzing, and evaluating *how* and *why* you did or did not improve. This is not an easy task for any writer, but it proves valuable for those who aim to improve their skills as communicators.

20.4 Annotated Sample Reading: “Don’t Expect Congrats” by Dale Trumbore

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Identify and analyze the elements and organizational pattern of a reflective essay.
- Demonstrate the ability to think critically about a writer’s reflections.

Introduction



FIGURE 20.4 Dale Trumbore

Dale Trumbore (https://openstax.org/r/Dale_Trumbore) (b. 1987) is a Southern California composer and writer. In addition to composing for chorus and orchestra, Trumbore often writes reflectively about artistic conflict and its resolution. In her book *Staying Composed* (2019), she writes about the anxiety and self-doubt that often accompany a career in the arts: "You have to be willing to be a little vulnerable. Real people are flawed." In the following blog post, she reflects on gender in her career field.

LIVING BY THEIR OWN WORDS

Womanhood and Composition

I am a female composer. As such, my compositions have been programmed on a concert about motherhood, though I do not have children; neither did most of the other women programmed on that concert. I've been asked mid-composition to change the theme of a piece, so the commission would relate to womanhood. (I did, but I didn't rewrite the minute-and-a-half of music I'd composed back when the commission's theme was "outer space.") I've been asked to sum up what it means to be a woman in a one-minute piece; I tried, but that piece ended up being about exactly how impossible the task is.

Establishing Context. *Trumbore sets up the conditions for this reflective essay by mentioning some of the challenges she has encountered and what she has done about them. She also mentions the difficulty of trying to "sum up" the entirety of her experience as a woman.*

The hundredth anniversary of the ratification of the 19th Amendment… in 2020… and the aftermath of the #MeToo movement have created a perfect storm of what I think of as Lady Composer Commissions: pieces that ask the composer to reflect the experience of being a woman in her work. Equally popular these days is the Lady Composer Concert, which 1) features works by composers who identify as women, and 2) connects the music of these composers for no reason other than that they all share a gender identity.

Context. *By providing additional context, Trumbore gives readers some background information and insight into the focus of the essay.*

Promotion of these concerts on social media often goes like this: "We're so excited to feature the work of Lady Composer 1, Lady Composer 2, Lady Composer 3, Lady Composer 4 [etc.]!" The general tone of these posts seems to be: "Look at all of the women we rounded up! We found so many of them!" When I am tagged in these posts, I never know whether to share them, like them, or un-tag myself as quickly as possible and hope the conductor doesn't notice.

Observation. *Trumbore points to part of the social and culture disparity between genders and questions how to respond. This reflection shows awareness of her discomfort and uncertainty about larger meanings.*

Now, I know these concerts mean well, and I would certainly never tell anyone to stop programming the works of underrepresented composers. As someone who relies on commissions and royalties to pay the rent, I'm also grateful to have my music programmed on any concert at all. But every time I'm tagged in a post for a concert like this—with no theme other than "Here's A Bunch of Lady Composers"—I feel as though someone has drawn a sharp-edged square around my identity. I am positive that these concerts are programmed with earnest and kind intentions; nevertheless, they make me wonder whether any conductor thinks I want to be programmed like this, like I am some exotic and fragile butterfly to be pinned down, labeled appropriately, and locked away in a glass box.

Purpose. *Trumbore uses reflection to see the larger purpose of the concerts. She also questions that purpose and uses the metaphor of a butterfly to emphasize the situation as she leads into the main purpose of the essay.*

One of my two cats, Cotton, is obsessed with catching and eating flies. He'll stalk one around our small house for hours before he finally catches and eats the thing, and he's nearly always more preoccupied with the stalking than the meal itself. But immediately after he's finally caught one, he comes over to my husband or me and meows, wanting recognition for his work: a gentle pat on the head, maybe, or a "Good job!" In our house, we call this routine "congrats," as in: "Cotton just swallowed his second fly of the day, then came over for more congrats."

Vignette and Description. *Trumbore breaks the flow of the essay with a vignette—a brief scene—offering a look into her life. The vignette connects this part of the essay with the next and establishes a concrete example of her feelings.*

This is exactly how the Lady Composer Concerts and their inevitable social media promotion have started to feel to me: like they are an elaborate exercise in seeking congrats. They are not programmed with the audience in mind; if anything, they come off as self-congratulatory. ("Look how woke we are!") If these concerts were serving the audience, they would have a theme beyond "a bunch of women wrote this music."

Metaphor. *Trumbore compares the cat's "congrats" routine with the promotion of the concerts.*

Purpose. *In addition, she reiterates the larger purpose of the essay by highlighting the topic of gender disparity.*

All you need to do to find this concept ridiculous, of course, is to flip the gender: Imagine a conductor saying that any random collection of pieces clearly belong together on the same program, because they all were written by men.

Analysis and Evaluation. *Trumbore defines what is not a valid concert theme and suggests that readers consider a new position—to judge the gender inequality situation among composers as she does.*

I am certainly not the first person to talk about this; I give the above example of gender-flipping whenever I talk about Lady Composer Concerts, and I've heard other friends do the same. Still, every time I bring this up, I hope it will be for the last time: "Music by Women" is not a theme. Collecting a bunch of pieces written by female composers does not in and of itself constitute an inspired concert program. It certainly doesn't deserve congrats.

Analysis. *Defining what she considers a theme, Trumbore continues to explain her position and elaborate on the reality she experiences.*

If you're called to promote the work of composers who identify as women, consider—the same as you would with

any other program—what the music and/or texts have in common. What's the through-line of this music or collection of texts, regardless of the gender of who wrote it? Is the experience of hearing these particular compositions enhanced by virtue of their sharing a program? Does the order of the program present a narrative? Are there any other pieces, including pieces by composers who identify as men, that would better round out this particular program?

Analysis. *These questions engage the reader and beg for answers while again pointing to her reflection on the concerts.*

Speculation. *Further, she is hinting at a way of changing the status quo in the questions she asks.*

Whenever I discuss "Women in Music"—something else I'm often asked to do—I'm struck once again by the fact that we're somehow still having the conversation about the lack of Lady Composers. I feel conflicted whenever I'm asked to talk about the role of women in music; I wish we didn't need to have that discussion, and I resent being asked to talk about it over and over again. At the same time, if I'd like to hear more conversations in the classical music world about systemic inequality—and I would—I have to be willing to talk about this myself.

Thoughts and Speculation. *Trumbore notes her frustrations with discussions focused on gender and music and then suggests that she would rather focus on the inequalities if she would be willing to discuss this issue.*

But a single Lady Composer Concert is unlikely to single-handedly resolve the fact that for centuries, classical music has revered the music of white, mostly dead, usually European men as the highest quality music of all time. In Music History classes, most of us are taught that this is the worthiest music to study. In Music Theory classes, we analyze these scores. Whenever we sing in a chorus, we are at the mercy of what our conductor presents as the worthiest music, and if that is exclusively the work of white and dead and European and male composers, who can blame us for subconsciously thinking that this is the music most worthy of programming?

Thoughts and Context. *Trumbore reflects on her education and notes some of the problematic, and perhaps sexist, elements of music education. Note again her use of questions to involve readers.*

We don't (just) have a lack of Lady Composers or a dearth of Lady Composer Concerts. We have an entire educational system designed to teach us to esteem the music of dead white men above the music of all other composers.

Analysis and Evaluation. *Trumbore responds to her own question and expands her rationale of reconsidering music education. In addition, the brevity of this paragraph encourages readers to focus on the larger message in the last sentence.*

So I'm more than happy to congratulate anyone championing the work of historically underrepresented composers. Yes, please! Let's talk about systemic oppression and racism and the discrimination that composers who are not white and/or male have faced for centuries. Let's talk about implicit bias and financial privilege and how all of it affects which voices we perceive as most worthy of our attention.

Speculation. *Trumbore drives home the point of the previous paragraph and makes it more explicit for readers, indicating what she would like to see happen.*

And yet it's equally important to acknowledge that no single concert will fix that systematic imbalance. If it was going to, the Lady Composer Concert would have already done this, because the Lady Composer Concert has been around for decades. The Lady Composer Concert is a stale concept; we've tried it already, and we're still having this conversation.

Speculation. *In this paragraph, Trumbore suggests a potentially new direction and opportunity, on which she elaborates in the next paragraph. In other words, through this reflection, she has arrived at a new way of seeing the world.*

I want to propose an idea that is new, though. If you truly want to champion the works of historically

underrepresented composers, what would it look like if you did the loudest work behind the scenes?

What if you had bold conversations about why you feel compelled to program more historically underrepresented groups of composers, but for the concert itself, you presented your program the same way you would any other program—highlighting the specific compositions, thematic material, and the reasons that your audience should come hear this music?

What if you championed compositions written by these composers without needing to mention their race or gender as part of the promotion of your concert? What if you identified instead what you find most meaningful, exceptional, and unique about their compositions?

And what if you told your peers about these works that you love? Over time, maybe that specificity—naming the pieces you love, not just a string of composers' names—would eliminate another common problem I've heard conductors discuss: trouble finding quality repertoire written by underrepresented composers.

Analysis and Speculation. *After a series of thoughtful questions about underrepresented groups of composers, Trumbore provides a way to move forward, not by giving directions, but by asking questions that lead readers to obvious answers.*

If you're having trouble finding such repertoire, let your peers and friend-colleagues know that you're searching for this work. Ask for recommendations. You can always reach out to composers directly with requests for perusal scores, too. I'm always more than happy to send along perusals when conductors are looking for new works, and I'm even happier if I'm asked for works that fit a specific theme. Getting to know a new composer's work can be as simple as sending them a quick email through their website's contact form. Ask if they have any pieces that might be a good fit for your upcoming concert season's themes. You might even name some of the other works you already have in mind for that program and see if that composer can recommend compatible works from their catalogue.

Thoughts and Speculation. *This paragraph continues setting up a way to move forward and helps connect it to the previous paragraphs. It reveals more of Trumbore's thoughts on what she wants to do and her ability to do it.*

Truth be told, I don't want to write another piece about "being a woman." I want to write pieces about emotions that are hard to capture in words but easy to express in music, because music has room to hold a staggering amount of complexity and nuance. I want to be given commissions with specific concert themes, even oddly specific ones. Especially oddly-specific ones; please, give me your commissions for works with texts about weddings that must also include percussion, or pieces to pair with Taiwanese music about the sea.

Evaluation. *Trumbore begins to use pathos and urges readers to understand her position. She also explains how she works and what works best for her.*

I will rise to each challenge; this is what I do for a living, and I'm good at my job. I'll find a text that adheres to each theme and write the best music I can write at this moment in time. I do this best when I don't also have to wonder whether I am single-handedly summing up the entirety of what it means to "be a woman." If the texts I choose or the music I write happens to capture some aspect of the female experience—of a female experience—great. Still, that will have been my decision to make.

Thoughts. *In reflecting, Trumbore acknowledges what she needs to do next and begins to gain momentum by describing specific activities to meet her goals.*

When you program the works of underrepresented composers, don't act like my cat does with a freshly-caught fly. Don't proudly rattle off the names of women in a Facebook post like you've hunted down their music and are laying it at the feet of your audience. Your audience deserves better; they deserve a concert with an actual theme.

Coherence. *By bringing back the cat, Trumbore reminds readers of the "congrats" metaphor she established earlier as she continues to advocate for needed change.*

When it comes time to promote the work of historically underrepresented composers, present their

compositions—these works you've come to love—as you would any other excellent repertoire. Shout from the rooftops why you love each composition. Tell your colleagues and friends. Tell your board members. Tell your audience. And once you have, don't expect congratulations for doing so. You don't need or deserve praise simply for doing your job as a conductor. After all, programming music that you admire and respect—sharing that music, teaching that music, advocating for that music—is reward enough. Isn't it?

Speculation. *In this concluding paragraph, Trumbore encourages action toward implementing her points, or at the very least toward a different way of thinking. The reflection encourages readers, too, to reflect on their feelings, their experiences, and potential ways to change or improve.*

Discussion Questions

1. What is the "happening," and which parts of Dale Trumbore's essay describe it?
2. What parts of Trumbore's essay show reflection?
3. What parts of Trumbore's essay describe an action that results from the reflection?
4. How does Trumbore use her cat to make a reflective point? What effect might it have for readers?
5. What might you do differently if you were Trumbore and wanted to focus on a similar topic?

20.5 Writing Process: Looking Back, Looking Forward

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Apply composing processes and tools as a means to discover and reconsider ideas.
- Reflect on the development and insights of composing processes and how they affect your work.
- Adapt and apply composing processes for a variety of technologies and modalities.

One of the best ways to reveal who you are as a writer is to show yourself becoming aware of your strengths and weakness. This awareness can help you discover not only new ways of seeing the world but also new insights into yourself. Although such awareness can occur for unexplainable reasons, it usually happens when you encounter new ideas or have experiences that change you in some way. Reflection allows you to begin this journey. To grow as a writer, look back at your previous writing. If you look back at a drawing you did in first grade, you might find it funny or cute. Additionally, and more likely than not, you could do that same drawing now with a lot more detail and skill than you did back then. Think about writing in the same way: as you add to your writing skills and abilities, you become more proficient and can take on more challenging writing tasks. In this section, as you reflect on your writing development during the course, you will find areas of strength and weakness. The weaker areas are the ones you will want to improve.

Prewriting

Before beginning your reflective essay, take some time to review your work from the course. Write a few sentences or paragraphs about specific aspects of each assignment, such as its purpose, your feelings, what you learned, what you did well (and not so well), and where you think you can do significantly better. This prewriting work will be useful later.

Summary of Assignment: Portfolio Reflection and Self-Evaluation

In the form of a letter (e.g., "Dear Reader"), respond to several questions and discuss various topics related to your writing development in this course. For example, you might be asked to identify and discuss your strongest piece of writing. For each claim you make about your strongest assignment, provide reasoning and evidence from your portfolio to support the statement. When you quote directly from your own writing, be sure to state which assignment or draft you are quoting. Within the context of your responses, include commentary on most of the following course topics as well as others that have been significant:

- Writing processes (organizing graphically, outlining, drafting, conferencing, revising, editing, publishing, recursivity)
- Rhetorical situation, rhetoric, and persuasion
- Reasoning strategies, textual and rhetorical analysis
- Evidentiary strategies: evaluation, research
- Word choice, leads, transitions
- Thesis statement, structure and organization, introductions, conclusions
- Showing, not telling; descriptive writing
- Voice; feelings, as hindsight or in process

Depending on the nature of your portfolio, you may be able to create a digital or multimodal reflective letter, as mentioned in Glance at Genre: Purpose and Structure.

Another Lens. Using reflective organization and strategies, create a fictionalized story for readers. Some fiction writers base their stories on real events, adding material or characters to help readers connect the plot points and make the story more memorable and engaging. For example, consider a school-like setting and a host of characters. Incorporate dialogue, details of setting, and other story elements to develop characters and create tension.

Once Upon a Time

> James sat silently across the room as Rafael read the paper James had worked so hard to write. He could not have been more nervous watching Rafael, the best writer in the class, review his work. No one had ever read James's work other than a teacher. His heart was racing, and beads of sweat formed on his forehead.
>
> "What do you think?" James asked. Rafael rolled his eyes before locking eyes with James.
>
> "I'm not finished yet," Rafael answered and returned to the paper, ignoring James.
>
> James stared at him, contemplating the meaning of every facial wrinkle and twitch of a finger: what did they mean? After several aching minutes, Rafael picked up a pen and wrote for several minutes with a slight smile on his face. He took a long breath, walked over to James, and handed the paper back with a sheet full of notes.
>
> He smiled and said, "It's a strong paper. I made some notes I hope you find useful. I was confused only a few times, so you could look at where I made suggestions for when you revise." James smiled back, and the look on his face showed surprise and relief.
>
> After quickly reviewing the comments, James turned to his close friend Jess and said, "He didn't destroy my paper and actually gave me some good suggestions."

In this example, James, Rafael, and Jess are not real people, but the characters show how students may react during a peer-review workshop. Of course, you might decide to write about a less-than-ideal experience in which Rafael laughs at James's work and Jess steps in to help him revise. Or you might set the story in a different time or place and create an entirely different situation. Whatever you decide, use your course experience and some creativity to create scenarios in which a character reflects on their writing in ways that are meaningful and useful not only for you but also for your readers. Then weave these characters into a larger narrative. It might end in a published class book or website of student writing and require James to give a speech about one of his papers, or it might end in another scenario that follows logically from the narrative you have created. Regardless of where you take the story, include realistic elements of reflection as well as how your main character develops across the story, faces a challenge, and finds a way to overcome it.

You can show character development in several different ways. One way is to be inside a character's mind. To portray a character thinking rather than talking, employ **internal monologue** by using sentence fragments and other nonacademic writing conventions to show that a person's thought process doesn't follow conventional rules of language. For example, a character named Bethany describes her thoughts when

revising her first paper. She writes an internal monologue—readers hear her talking to herself while she tries to focus on revision. Note how she provides clues for readers to understand what is going on around her.

> OMG, I cannot believe I wrote that! How could I write about a calligraphy pen when I don't even own a calligraphy pen? I'm not even sure what one looks like! Bonkers! I wonder if the other people in my class are staring at me right now. I'm afraid to look up. I casually tilt my head up and see no one paying any attention to me whatsoever. Wonderful! I'm just another writer in a writing class.

In this example, the character works through a process of reflection based on her experience. She cannot believe she wrote about a calligraphy pen, but perhaps because of her nervousness with writing, this quirk has become a unique aspect of her character. You might create other such quirks in one of your characters, such as a character who always reads aloud, even in the middle of class, or one who taps a pen on their forehead loudly as they read. Then you can use that as a tool to point to another aspect of what you learned in your actual course. When writing this fictionalized piece, be mindful of your focus, which is to reflect on your development as a writer during this course.

Quick Launch: Establishing Criteria for Growth

To get started, you will need to organize your thoughts. After you have reviewed each chapter and its related assignment, reflect on your successes and challenges. Use a graphic organizer similar to Table 20.1 to get started. If the information already filled in for Chapter 1 works for you, use it. If it doesn't, change it accordingly. If you skipped the suggested review of your assignments, do it now. Otherwise, use your notes as you complete the chapter reflection table below. Skip any rows related to chapters that you did not cover in class.

Chapter Number	Key Skills Learned	Successes	Challenges
1	Summarize, Analyze, Evaluate	Analyzing wasn't hard, but I learned to do it better because I really had to think about what the sentence meant and explain it in my own way.	I had a hard time with evaluation because I wasn't comfortable giving my opinion since I'm just a student. However, I got more comfortable writing about complex topics and ideas.
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			

TABLE 20.1 Chapter reflection table

Chapter Number	Key Skills Learned	Successes	Challenges
12			
13			
14			
15			
16			
17			
18			
19			
20			

TABLE 20.1 Chapter reflection table

Once you have completed your own version of the table, use it to guide you as you begin writing. Take each assignment and stay focused on its goal. In doing so, you may notice a pattern in the assignments that helped you learn. If you do, incorporate that pattern into your reflective essay, and use it to create a theme.

Drafting: Getting Started and Following Through

As you work through the task of reflecting, consider the purpose of each assignment and your approach to it, in addition to the information you have included in the chapter reflection table. Also, read some models to help stimulate your reflective thinking: Final Reflective Essay by Andrew Duffy (https://openstax.org/r/Andrew_Duffy); Final Reflection by Anthony Roco (https://openstax.org/r/Anthony_Roco); E-Portfolio Reflection by Sean Porter (https://openstax.org/r/Sean_Porter); or this Portfolio Summative Reflection (https://openstax.org/r/Portfolio_Summative). Then, use the template below as a way to create your own unique reflection on yourself as a developing writer. Focus on the larger impact of what you have learned. Also offer some insight on what you still need to work on, and explain why. Each aspect that you write about will show a level of progress and awareness toward improvement. Just as important, it will help you focus on future

writing assignments and allow you to recognize your growth as a writer.

Portfolio Reflection Template

Dear Reader,

Welcome to my English Composition portfolio. Here, you will find _____.

Complete this statement: *This semester, I learned that I am (not) a writer because* _____.

Answer these questions in paragraph form. For each claim you make, show your reasoning and provide quoted evidence from your portfolio:

- Which is the strongest piece of writing in the portfolio?
  - What are the strengths of this essay, and why do you think so?
  - In what specific ways has your writing improved this semester?
  - How does this essay demonstrate this improvement?
- Which is the least effective piece of writing in the portfolio?
  - What are the weaknesses of this essay, and why do you think so?
  - If you could revise this essay one more time, what would you change, and why?
  - Specifically, which writing skills still need work, and how will you continue to work on them?
- How did the process of revision help you re-envision your essays and make changes?
  - In what ways was it useful to see what other students were writing?
  - How did knowing that others would provide feedback during drafting affect your writing process?
  - How did revision affect your skills as a peer workshop partner?
- In what ways did your writing process evolve over the course of the semester?
  - Discuss the issue of perspective, such as when you first entered the course and now.
  - What did you learn about writing through its genres, elements of the rhetorical situation, processes, skills, and strategies?
  - How have you changed as a writer?
  - How have your feelings about writing changed?
- Finish this statement: *Before I took this class, I never knew* _____.

Sincerely,

Your Name

TABLE 20.2

Structuring Your Responses

As you respond to each of the questions above, use a paragraph planner such as this one.

Topic Sentence/Claim	Reasoning Strategy (Circle All Used)	Quoted Evidence from Portfolio
	Revisit Reasoning Strategies: Improving Critical Thinking to find frames and word banks that will help you employ these strategies.	
The strongest piece of writing in my portfolio is _____ because _____.	Analogy Cause and effect Classification and division Comparison and contrast Problem and solution Definition	Shows my use of descriptive writing/figurative language: "Learning a foreign language is like learning to ride a bicycle: you must learn to perform multiple tasks at the same time."
The strengths of this essay are _____, _____, and _____.	Analogy Cause and effect Classification and division Comparison and contrast Problem and solution Definition	
This semester, I improved my skills as a writer in the following ways: _____ and _____.	Analogy Cause and effect Classification and division Comparison and contrast Problem and solution Definition	
This essay demonstrates these skills in that it _____.	Analogy Cause and effect Classification and division Comparison and contrast Problem and solution Definition	

TABLE 20.3 Paragraph planner

20.6 Editing Focus: Pronouns

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Demonstrate knowledge of linguistic structures, including grammar.
- Implement appropriate pronouns in written work.

You likely use **Pronouns** —words that substitute for nouns or noun phrases—in every text that you write, including this portfolio reflection. Pronouns are one of the eight main parts of speech, the others being nouns, verbs, adverbs, adjectives, prepositions, conjunctions, and interjections.

Reference, Antecedent, and Case

Reference

Pronoun reference is the practice of using pronouns to replace nouns. The important thing to know about pronoun reference is that every pronoun must match the noun it replaces in terms of gender and number. **Gender** refers to the noun as either masculine, feminine, or neuter.

Masculine: Jorge is an educated man. **He** is Toby's neighbor.

Feminine: Rico's **sister** decided to go skating. **She** came back early.

Neuter: The **car** has four new **tires**. **It** runs much better with **them**.

However, if you're not certain of someone's gender identity or don't want to project it on them, use the gender-neutral pronouns *them*, *they*, and *their*. See Spotlight on... Pronouns in Context for more about using gender-neutral pronouns.

Gender neutral: Pat likes to eat pizza. They like pineapple and bacon with lots of cheese.

Number means singular or plural.

Singular: Toby has **one daughter**. **She** is studying art.

Plural: Jorge has **two children**. **They** go to the same school.

In addition to gender and number, **clarity** is often a major issue when using pronouns. For example: *When Lizzie smacked her arm into the glass window, she broke it.* Did Lizzie break her arm, or did she break the window? In this case, the reference is not clear. One way to clarify the meaning would be to write the sentence this way: *Lizzie broke the window when she smacked her arm into it.*

Antecedent

The **antecedent** is the noun, nouns, or other pronoun or pronouns that the pronoun replaces. The antecedent usually appears earlier in the sentence or in a previous sentence, and the pronoun appears later in the same sentence or in another sentence.

Example 1: Although my **friends** tease me about my dancing style, I love **them** anyway.

Example 2: Mariah said **she** wanted to go home.

Example 3: The **car** was far away. Jessica couldn't see what model **it** was.

Case

Pronoun case refers to the grammatical function of the pronoun in a sentence. Pronouns that are the **subjects** (the person, place, or thing that performs the action of the verb or represents what or whom sentence is about) of a sentence are written in the **subjective case**. For example: ***I*** *like pizza*. Pronouns that are **objects** (nouns or pronouns affected by the action of a verb) of a sentence or preposition are written in the **objective case**. For

example: *Laura gave **him** the baseball. Jorge and Toby were standing in front of **us** in line*. Lastly, **possessive pronouns** pronouns show ownership and are written in the **possessive case**. For example: *The cat picked up **its** toy. Those notes are **his** and **mine**.*

You already know that you cannot have a sentence without a subject and that subjects and objects in sentences must be nouns or pronouns. Remember, a pronoun is a stand-in for a noun. It is always playing substitute for a noun or nouns "already out there somewhere." Imagine writing without pronouns:

> When **Marcy** woke this morning, **Marcy** had a headache, so **Marcy** went to **Marcy's** medicine cabinet and took one of **Marcy's** headache pills that **Marcy's** doctor had prescribed for **Marcy**.

Instead:

> When Marcy woke this morning, **she** had a headache, so **she** went to **her** medicine cabinet and took one of **her** headache pills that **her** doctor had prescribed for **her**.

Types of Pronouns

When you think of pronouns, **personal pronouns** such as those discussed in the previous section, referring to a specific person or object, are likely the first that come to mind. However, the world of pronouns extends to reflexive, indefinite, and demonstrative pronouns as well.

Personal Pronouns

Knowing the difference between **subject personal pronouns** and **object personal pronouns** will help you use them correctly.

Form	First Person	Second Person	Third Person
Subject	I, we	you	he, she, it, they
Object	me, us	you	him, her, it, them
Possessive	my, mine, our, ours	your, yours	his, hers, its, their, theirs

TABLE 20.4

Subject Position	Object Position
I	me
you	you
she	her
he	him
it	it
we	us
they	them
who	whom
whoever	whomever

TABLE 20.5

Seeing both versions across from each other helps emphasize that each personal pronoun has its counterpart. In other words, if it isn't *we*, then it is *us*, and if it isn't *me*, then it is *I*.

Correct → ***She*** *is such a sweet little dog.*

Incorrect → ***Her*** *is such a sweet little dog.*

It is fairly obvious here which pronoun is correct. You have been saying it correctly all along, probably without being able to articulate the grammatical rule that made you do so. However, knowing the subject or **object distinction** can be especially helpful in knowing whether to use *I* or *me*. People often make mistakes when a sentence has a plural object. For example:

Jasmine and **I** ordered pizza for dinner. The pizza was delivered to Jasmine and **me**.

In the first sentence, the plural subject is *Jasmine* and *I*. *I* is the subject personal pronouns. In the second sentence, *me* is an **object of the preposition** (*to*), and the object personal pronoun—*me*—is correct. If the second sentence had the singular object pronoun *me*, no problem would arise. You would simply say that the pizza was delivered *to me*, not *to I*. Remember that an object personal pronoun stays an object personal pronoun no matter how many other objects are part of it.

Reflexive Pronouns

Reflexive pronouns are straightforward. They are pronouns that "reflect," as an image does in a mirror. They refer to the same person or thing.

John couldn't stop looking at **himself** in the mirror.

John is the original noun, or antecedent, and *himself* is the pronoun that points back at him. Note that reflexive pronouns *always* end in *self* or *selves*.

First Person	Second Person	Third Person
myself, ourselves	yourself, yourselves	himself, herself, itself, themselves

TABLE 20.6

Indefinite Pronouns

While reflexive pronouns always refer to themselves—that is, the subject and object are the same person, place, thing, or idea—**indefinite pronouns** are the opposite. As their name suggests, they are not definite; they are *in*definite and do not refer to specific nouns. They do get their meaning across, but the nouns they refer to are not known. These are some of the most common indefinite pronouns:

all	either	most	other
another	everybody	much	several
any	everyone	nobody	some
anybody	everything	none	somebody
anything	few	no one	someone
both	many	nothing	something
each	more	one	

TABLE 20.7

Demonstrative Pronouns

Demonstrative pronouns point directly at something. They use all their pronoun power to indicate their preference, so much so that when someone uses a demonstrative pronoun, it is hard *not* to imagine them pointing at something directly. Good news and bad news come along with demonstrative pronouns. The good news is that there are only four demonstrative pronouns: *this*, *that*, *these*, and *those*. The bad news—and it's not really bad—is that words that commonly play the role of pronouns are multitalented. The same word can play another role (part of speech) in a sentence. Sometimes these four words function as **adjectives**, which always modify nouns and pronouns. In the sentence *That is my car*, the word *that* is playing the role of a pronoun. It is the subject of the sentence. Only nouns or pronouns can be subjects. However, if the sentence read *That car is mine*, then *that* would be an adjective because it modifies (tells something about) the noun *car*.

Common Mix-Ups

- **It's** vs. **its:** This is an easy one to mix up but easy to correct. **It's** means **it is** or **it has**. For example: ***It's*** *a hot day* or ***It is*** *a hot day*. **Its** refers to possession. For example: *This car has* ***its*** *problems*. To be sure you are correct, substitute *it is*. To say *The car has* ***it is*** *problems* makes no sense, so **its** is correct.
- **Who** vs. **whom:** Perhaps the most effective way to recognize which to use is to equate **who** to *he* and **whom** to *him*. For example: ***Who/Whom*** *wrote the book?* ***He*** *wrote the book*, so *who* is correct. Remember that *whom* is in the objective case. Think about it like this: ***whom*** is like *them*, so you might say, *This is for them*. Therefore, *This is for whom?* or *Whom is this for?* would be correct.
- **I** vs. **me: I** is always a subject; **me** is always an object. So *Demarcus and I left the building* is correct

because *I* is the subject. Conversely, *Give the package to me* and *You gave me good advice* are both correct because *me* is an object. Remember to use the correct pronoun with compound objects, as in the sentence *Reflection has helped other class members and **me** improve our writing.*

In Chapter 20, you have learned how to use different types of pronouns to substitute for nouns and noun phrases. You have also learned about common mix-ups when using pronouns.

Access multimedia content (http://openstax.org/books/writing-guide/pages/20-6-editing-focus-pronouns)

20.7 Evaluation: Evaluating Self-Reflection

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Articulate how genre conventions for structure, tone, and mechanics vary.
- Evaluate a written work for critical language awareness, clarity and coherence, and rhetorical choices.

As you know, one of the most important aspects of improving as a writer is the ability to evaluate yourself and your writing. Certainly, writing assignments help you, but it is important to learn this kind of evaluation for yourself and work to improve. Moreover, as you deconstruct your writing, you will recognize some aspects that carry over to other courses and disciplines, thus demonstrating the universality of writing. Use this rubric to help you plan, write, or review your reflective essay.

Rubric

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
5 **Skillful**	The text always adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: clear use of pronouns, as discussed in Section 20.6. The text shows ample evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The writer consistently explains their progress, clearly demonstrating purpose and a combination of thought and narrative in an expert way. Well-chosen transitions and consistently clear connective ideas link the parts of the reflection.	The writer consistently provides meaningful analysis, examples, explanations, observations, speculation, and honest criticism that lead to a thoughtful and purposeful self-evaluation.
4 **Accomplished**	The text usually adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: clear use of pronouns, as discussed in Section 20.6. The text shows some evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The writer explains their progress, clearly demonstrating purpose and a combination of thought and narrative. Transitions, if not always enough, and generally clear connective ideas link the parts of the reflection.	The writer usually provides meaningful analysis, examples, explanations, observations, speculation, and honest criticism that lead to purposeful and thoughtful self-evaluation. However, some areas may be somewhat less developed than others.

TABLE 20.8

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
3 **Capable**	The text generally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: clear use of pronouns, as discussed in Section 20.6. The text shows limited evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The writer explains their progress, if not always clearly demonstrating purpose and a combination of thought and narrative. Some transitions help achieve coherence, but there are not quite enough, nor are ideas consistently connected.	The writer provides some meaningful analysis, examples, explanations, observations, speculation, and honest, if sometimes superficial, criticism that lead to purposeful and occasionally thoughtful self-evaluation. Some or even most areas may be less developed than others.
2 **Developing**	The text occasionally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: clear use of pronouns, as discussed in Section 20.6. The text shows emerging evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The writer attempts to explain their progress but does not clearly demonstrate purpose or a combination of thought and narrative. There may be too much of one or too little of both. Transitions are either missing or ineffective, as are connecting ideas. The essay may be difficult to follow throughout or in places.	The writer provides a minimum of meaningful details, analysis, examples, explanations, observations, speculation, and honest criticism that lead to purposeful and thoughtful self-evaluation. Some or even most areas may be far less developed than others, or all areas may need considerable elaboration.
1 **Beginning**	The text does not adhere to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: clear use of pronouns, as discussed in Section 20.6. The text shows little to no evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The paper shows little or no progression through the writer's growth and demonstrates minimal attention to purpose or a combination of thought and narrative in a useful way. There may be too much of one or too little of both. Transitions are either missing or ineffective, and the essay may be difficult to follow throughout or in places.	The writer provides few meaningful details, analysis, examples, explanations, observations, speculation, or honest criticism that leads to purposeful and thoughtful self-evaluation. Most areas are seriously undeveloped.

TABLE 20.8

20.8 Spotlight on … Pronouns in Context

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Recognize and avoid gender bias in writing and general language use.
- Apply conventions of usage and current terminology to writing, including gender-neutral pronouns when applicable.

By now, you have a working knowledge of what pronouns are and how to use them. This section focuses on

more nuanced uses of pronouns and their place in the contemporary world—an emerging field of interest as people work to develop language that best captures their multiple identities.

Eliminating Gender Bias

It is important to remember that many thoughtful and powerful English-language works from the past took masculine words for granted. English use of words such as *man*, *men*, *he*, *him*, and *his* was, one would hope, meant to include both men and women. Consider Thomas Jefferson's "All men are created equal" and Thomas Paine's "These are the times that try men's souls." The contemporary equivalent of those words might be "All people are created equal" and "These are the times that try our souls," which are two of several possible fixes for such gender exclusivity. When you read historic texts, recognize that the rules were different then, and the writers are no more at fault than the culture in which they lived. Contemporary writing, however, should reflect inclusivity, which in turn reflects the culture in which you live today. (See Spotlight on... Bias in Language and Research for more about language bias.)

As you edit to avoid gender-biased language, you will notice that English does not have an agreed-upon gender-neutral third-person singular pronoun to match the gender-neutral third-person plural pronouns (*they*, *their*, *them*). Writers and speakers use *he* (*him*, *his*) for men and *she* (*her*, *hers*) for women. In the sentence "Everybody has his own opinion," the indefinite pronoun *everybody* needs a singular pronoun to refer to it. Although it is grammatically correct to say, "Everybody has his own opinion," the sentence excludes women. But until recently, it was considered grammatically questionable to write, "Everybody has their own opinion," although *their* is gender neutral. When editing, be alert to such constructions, and consider these ways to use or fix them:

- Make the sentence plural: "People have their own opinions."
- Include both pronouns *(This solution excludes people who do not fall within a gender binary.):* "Everybody has his or her own opinion."
- Eliminate the pronoun: "Everybody has an opinion."
- Alternate masculine and feminine pronouns throughout your sentences or paragraphs, using *she* in one paragraph and *he* in the next. Be careful, though; to avoid confusing readers, you might change them in each section or chapter.

Most writers have used all of these solutions at one time or another. As always, use the strategy that makes for the clearest, most graceful writing.

Additionally, it has become more common and generally accepted to use *they*, *their*, and *them* as singular pronouns. However, depending on the context, using a plural pronoun to refer to a single individual can be confusing to readers when its antecedent is unclear.

Pronouns for Nonbinary and Transgender People

You cannot always know how individuals identify themselves, nor can you assume their gender is either male or female. The best approach with people you don't know is simply to ask which pronouns they prefer and to respect their choice. Some people identify themselves with the pronouns *they/them/theirs*, and this preference is generally acceptable politically, socially, and grammatically. Other gender-neutral pronouns exist as well, such as *ze/hir/hirs*, but they are used less often. If you are unsure, an option is simply to use the person's name.

If an individual has a specific identity and prefers a masculine, feminine, or gender-neutral pronoun, there are ways they can inform people of it. (Notice the use here of *they* as a singular pronoun.) For example, if one identifies as female, that person can include the pronouns *she/her* as part of their email signature: "Jane Doe (she/her)." Similarly, a person who identifies as nonbinary can include the preferred pronouns *they/them/their* in their signature.

Write about Pronouns

Take a moment and write about how pronoun use impacts you. Also, write about how people understand each other through pronouns, while being mindful of the differences between people. Think carefully about perspectives on gender, and be sure to respect other points of view and interpretations of pronoun use. Finally, explain how pronoun use is an important component of identity.

As an additional exercise, review your portfolio and (re)consider your use of pronouns. Your development as a writer and enhanced understanding of pronouns will provide new insight into their use. *Where might you have made other decisions about pronouns, and what impact might they have had?* Consider including these insights in your reflective essay.

Avoid Discriminatory Language

Above all, your writing should not hurt people or exclude any group from humanity. As you edit, ensure that your language does not discriminate against categories of people based on gender, race, ethnicity, social class, or sexual orientation—or anything else.

Further Reading

The following texts provide additional information or examples regarding reflective writing in various disciplines and settings.

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